

to see when they return home. Your kitchen-top could become a giant tablet, on which you can view recipes and how-to videos. The milk pan can sense when the milk is about to boil over and automatically turn off the stove.

Now, if all this convenience has made you cook and eat more than ever before, then you should start using smart dining ware like Smart-Plate and HAPIfork, which work with mobile apps to control your diet.

Not interested in new appliances

You do not have to necessarily go about buying new connected appliances if you want to smarten your house. There are innumerable DIY kits available today that enable you to automate your home in any way possible. As easy as fitting Lego blocks, that is how German startup digitalSTROM wants home automation to be. These little colourful blocks can be fitted into your existing electrical infrastructure to add an element of intelligence to everything from your lights to your kitchen-tops.

There are loads of smartswitches and smartplugs available today, from international and Indian manufacturers. These enable you to switch on or off practically any electric-powered device from anywhere, using your smartphone. This makes a lot of sense for somebody who is just toying with the idea of home automation.

One app to rule them all

Though it is nice to have a home full of smartdevices, it can be a headache managing these if each one had a separate app and each used a different protocol. "There is no doubt that there is growing popularity of smartdevices, be it wearables, tablets, smartphones, extending to smarthermes and even smartcities. However, these systems are under constant pressure to deliver the correct functionality at the right time, and at the right speed. The chal-

lenges these face are power and cost. Though flexibility and adaptability are guaranteed once we shift to these systems, there are issues involved in handling multiple connected devices. It is important that all these devices are connected over a converged Internet Protocol (IP) network. This will help pave the



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way for interactive, seamless and personalised services," says Sanjay Gupta, India country manager, NXP Semiconductors. NXP works with ecosystem partners to enable seamless, secure interconnectivity across smartdevices, agnostic to the wireless connectivity protocols used.

There are a number of easy-to-use, plug-and-play hubs and apps that help you manage several devices using one dashboard. In most cases,

the hubs are also capable of handling more than one communications protocol, extending the choice of devices that can be connected and managed through these. From Apple HomeKit to Wink, Samsung SmartThings, Staples Connect and Revolv, there are lots of choices in this space. In order to simplify home management, it is better you choose devices that are compatible with a single platform so you can unify these easily.

Google Weave. This is a cross-platform protocol and infrastructure, which aims to unify products from several manufacturers onto a single platform, to make it easy to set up and manage multiple devices from smartphones and the Web.

Weave aims to provide standardised schemas that can define device interoperability regardless of brand or manufacturer. This not only makes it easy for users but also for developers, who can develop apps for the physical, connected world, just like they would for Android or iOS devices.

Nest Weave. This is not the same as Google's Weave although Google owns Nest. Nest's Weave is a communications protocol based on Thread, which Nest has been using for several years now. In a smart move, Nest has now opened up this secure, reliable, low-power, low-latency (100ms), peer-to-peer connection standard for other smart home device manufacturers to use.

In a Weave network, devices talk to one another directly without going through a mobile app or a router. This means that the network is up even when Wi-Fi connection is down. This makes it ideal for always-on devices like smartlocks.

Products that adopt Nest protocol are certified as 'Works with Nest.' Once such a product is added to a home that already has another Nest product, there is practically no set up involved. The device immediately syncs with other devices and gets recognised by the apps also, making it easy to manage multiple devices.